

Session 33: Metaphors for Death in Hebrew Poetry

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors place poems at key moments in the story when God gives an Eden moment to his people.
- These inset poems take individual narratives about the Israelites and apply them to the cosmic story line of the whole biblical narrative.

Jonah's Song Compared With Other Songs of Deliverance

Jonah's prayer has much in common with the other inset prayers in the Hebrew Bible that take place either right after or right before deliverance. The key study here was done by James Watts in [Psalm and Story: Inset Hymns in Hebrew Narrative](#).

Notably, all of these examples contain images of either rescue from dangerous waters or ascent from the grave into the land of the living.

Poems of Thanksgiving After Deliverance

Exodus 15:1-13 NASB

¹ Then Moses and the sons of Israel sang this song to the LORD, and said,
"I will sing to the LORD, for he is highly exalted;
the horse and its rider he has hurled into the sea.

² The LORD is my strength and song,
and he has become my salvation ...

⁴ Pharaoh's chariots and his army he has cast into the sea;
and the choicest of his officers are drowned in the Sea of Reed.

⁵ The deeps cover them;
they went down into the depths like a stone. ...

⁸ At the blast of your nostrils the waters were piled up,
the flowing waters stood up like a heap;
the deeps were congealed in the heart of the sea. ...

¹⁰ You blew with your wind, the sea covered them;
they sank like lead in the mighty waters. ...

¹² You stretched out your right hand,
the underworld swallowed them.

¹³ In your lovingkindness you have led the people whom you have redeemed;
in your strength you have guided to your holy habitation."

2 Samuel 22:4-7, 16-18 NASB

⁴ I call upon the LORD, who is worthy to be praised,
and I am saved from my enemies.

⁵ For the waves of death encompassed me;
the torrents of destruction overwhelmed me;

⁶ the cords of Sheol surrounded me;
the snares of death confronted me.

⁷ In my distress I called upon the LORD,
yes, I cried to my God;
and from his temple he heard my voice,
and my cry for help came into his ears. ...

¹⁶ Then the channels of the sea appeared,
the foundations of the world were laid bare
by the rebuke of the LORD,
at the blast of the breath of his nostrils.

¹⁷ He sent from on high, he took me;
he drew me out of many waters.

¹⁸ He delivered me from my strong enemy,
from those who hated me, for they were too strong for me.

Judges 5:19-21 NASB*

¹⁹ The kings came and fought;
then fought the kings of Canaan
at Taanach near the waters of Megiddo;
they took no plunder in silver.

²⁰ The stars fought from heaven,
from their courses they fought against Sisera.

²¹ The river of Kishon swept them away,
the ancient river, the torrent Kishon.
O my soul, march on with strength.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Poems of Thanksgiving Right Before Deliverance

1 Samuel 2:5-8 NASB

⁵ Those who were full hire themselves out for bread,
but those who were hungry cease to hunger.
Even the barren gives birth to seven,
but she who has many children languishes.

⁶ The LORD kills and makes alive;
he brings down to Sheol and raises up.

⁷ The LORD makes poor and rich;
he brings low, he also exalts.

⁸ He raises the poor from the dust,
he lifts the needy from the ash heap
to make them sit with nobles,
and inherit a seat of honor;
for the pillars of the earth are the LORD's,
and he set the world on them.

Isaiah 38:10-11, 18-20 NASB

¹⁰ I said, "In the middle of my life
I am to enter the gates of Sheol;
I am to be deprived of the rest of my years."

¹¹ I said, "I will not see the LORD,
the LORD in the land of the living;
I will look on man no more among the inhabitants of the world. ...

¹⁸ For Sheol cannot thank you,
death cannot praise you;
those who go down to the pit cannot hope for your faithfulness.

¹⁹ It is the living who give thanks to you, as I do today;
a father tells his sons about your faithfulness.

²⁰ The LORD will surely save me;
so we will play my songs on stringed instruments
all the days of our life at the house of the LORD."

The Cosmology of Biblical Poetry

These inset poems all occur in stories of Yahweh providing some kind of deliverance and rescue for his people. But notice that each poem magnifies the scope of the rescue to cosmic proportions. In this way, the biblical authors show their interest in telling us the story of God's wider purposes to rescue all humanity and all creation.

Notice also that each poem assumes the cosmology of Genesis 1-2, namely the three-tiered world of sky-land-sea, and each realm is associated with unique theological themes.

Sky

The sky is the divine realm of life and is poetically linked to mountains, high rocks, the temple, and God's heavenly temple.

Psalms 11:4 NIV*

The LORD is in his holy temple;
the LORD is on his heavenly throne.
He observes everyone on the land;
his eyes examine them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 66:1 NIV*

“The heavens are my throne
and the land is my footstool.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Land

The land is the human and animal realm, floating by God’s power above the sea and bordered by the sea.

Proverbs 8:27-29 NIV

²⁷ I was there when he set the heavens in place,
when he marked out the horizon on the face of the deep,
²⁸ when he established the clouds above
and fixed securely the fountains of the deep,
²⁹ when he gave the sea its boundary,
so the waters would not overstep his command,
and when he marked out the foundations of the earth.

Psalms 24:1-2 NASB*

¹ The land is the LORD’s, and all it contains,
the world, and those who dwell in it.
² For he has founded it upon the seas
and established it upon the rivers.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 75:3 NASB*

The land ...
it is I who have set it upon its pillars

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Wilderness

The wilderness is the uncultivated land and the realm of death. It is hostile to human flourishing.

Sea

Like the wilderness, the sea is a realm of death and disorder. It is poetically depicted as the deep, the waters under the land, the grave/sheol, and even the giant sea monster.

Psalms 69:1-2, 15 NASB

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have threatened my life.
² I have sunk in deep mire, and there is no foothold;

I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me. ...

¹⁵ May the flood of water not overflow me
nor the deep swallow me up,
nor the pit shut its mouth on me.

Psalm 88:3-7 NASB

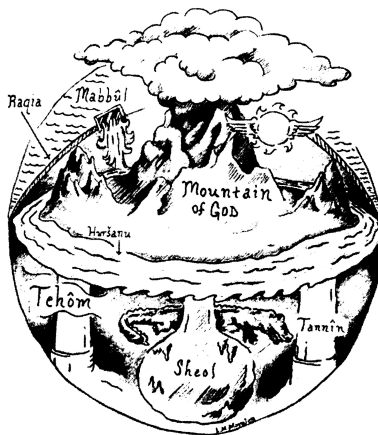
³ For my soul has had enough troubles,
and my life has drawn near to Sheol.

⁴ I am reckoned among those who go down to the pit;
I have become like a man without strength,

⁵ forsaken among the dead,
like the slain who lie in the grave,
whom you remember no more,
and they are cut off from your hand.

⁶ You have put me in the lowest pit,
in dark places, in the depth. ...

⁷ And you have afflicted me with all your waves.



Morales, L. Michael (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*. IVP Academic.

Reflection Question

What are some of the images or metaphors used for coming near to death in Hebrew poetry? Which of these occur in Jonah's poem?